

30 Years After Landmark ILO Convention, Home-Based Workers Still Fight for Equality

From: Al Jazeera Mined: 2026-06-20 5 min read

On a scorching afternoon in a working-class Delhi neighborhood, 38-year-old Shehnaz Bano sits on the cracked floor of her one-room home, stitching leather jacket panels. For each piece a sleeve, a back, a shoulder yoke she spends hours of **meticulous labor**. Her pay: 100 rupees, about \$1. "Imagine if I was a regular employee doing the same work on a factory floor. I would have been paid more, right?" Bano asks. "Just because I work from home, I don't get equal pay or rights." Bano is one of an estimated 260 million home-based workers (HBWs) worldwide people who produce goods or services in or near their homes, often in the **informal economy**. They lack minimum wages, **social security**, paid leave, or regulated hours. And 57% are women, according to a 2024 estimate by the research group WIEGO. Exactly 30 years ago today, on June 20, 1996, the International Labour Organization (ILO) adopted Convention 177, the first international standard to recognize HBWs as workers entitled to the same rights as traditional employees. Renana Jhabvala, a 73-year-old Indian activist with the Self Employed Women's Association (SEWA), was in the Geneva hall when it passed. "Discussions had gone on for nearly 21 days, but none of us knew whether the Convention would get adopted," she recalled. "There was a majority in the final vote and the Convention got passed." Yet only 13 countries have ratified it, none from South Asia, despite the region having the largest concentration of HBWs and being a hub of global supply chains. Deepa Bharathi, an ILO gender specialist, explains that home-based work in South Asia is often embedded in complex **subcontracting chains**, making employment relationships hard to identify and regulate. Moreover, because most HBWs are women, their work is frequently dismissed as an extension of household duties. "This undervaluation, combined with broader **gender inequalities**, has been a significant barrier to ratification and implementation," Bharathi said. For Bano and millions like her, the convention's promise remains unfulfilled. Activists argue that without legal recognition, these workers remain invisible to policymakers, trapped in low pay and unsafe conditions. The ILO says the focus must now be on visibility, fair pay, social protection, and a stronger collective voice so that 30 years of waiting finally turns into action.

Word Treasure

meticulous labor -- Work that requires very careful attention to every tiny detail.

informal economy -- The part of a country's economy where workers do not have official contracts, legal protections, or steady taxes.

social security -- Government programs that provide financial help to people during unemployment, illness, old age, or after a workplace accident.

ILO Convention 177 -- A 1996 international agreement that says people who work from home should get the same rights and pay as factory workers.

subcontracting chains -- A system where one company hires another company to do a job, which may hire someone else, making it hard to know who is

the real employer.

gender inequalities -- Differences in treatment, opportunities, or pay that harm one gender, most often women and girls.

Background you need

The International Labour Organization (ILO), founded in 1919 as part of the Treaty of Versailles, is a United Nations agency that sets minimum international labor standards for wages, safety, and working conditions.

ILO Convention 177 was created because home-based workers -- often stitching clothes, assembling electronics, or rolling incense -- had fallen completely outside national labor laws, leaving them without medical leave or retirement income.

South Asia is the world's center for such hidden labor: millions of women in India, Bangladesh, and Pakistan work in their homes for global clothing and leather supply chains, but because they are not on factory payrolls, governments rarely count them in official statistics.

The research group WIEGO (Women in Informal Employment: Globalizing and Organizing) estimates that worldwide, nearly 8 in 10 workers in the poorest countries earn their living in the informal economy, meaning they have no safety net.

In India, the Self Employed Women's Association (SEWA), a trade union for informal women workers founded in 1972, fought for years to have home-based work recognized as real work, a battle that contributed directly to the adoption of Convention 177.

Break it down

LEAD: A personal portrait -- Shehnaz Bano stitching leather panels on a cracked floor for \$1 per piece.

+ EMOTIONAL PUNCH: Her question -- "If I worked in a factory, I would be paid more, right?"

KEY STATISTIC: 260 million home-based workers globally, 57% women, according to WIEGO.

HISTORICAL MILESTONE: The 30th anniversary of ILO Convention 177, the first international standard for HBWs.

+ HUMAN MEMORY: Activist Renana Jhabvala recalls the tense vote in Geneva where 21 days of talks led to a surprise majority.

+ FAILED PROMISE: Only 13 countries have ratified the convention, none from South Asia.

OBSTACLES: Deepa Bharathi explains why ratification remains so low.

+ INVISIBLE CHAINS: Subcontracting makes it hard to identify who the real employer is.

+ GENDER BIAS: Women's home-based work is dismissed as an extension of household chores.

CURRENT REALITY: The gap between the convention's promise and workers' lives.

CALL TO ACTION: The ILO says visibility, fair pay, social protection, and a collective voice are the priorities.

Why it matters

The cheap clothes and accessories you buy are often stitched in rooms like Shehnaz Bano's -- your everyday purchases connect you to an enormous invisible workforce that lacks the basic rights you might take for granted at a future part-time job.

Test what you remember

1. How much does Shehnaz Bano earn for each leather jacket panel she stitches?
 - (A) 50 rupees
 - (B) 100 rupees
 - (C) 1 dollar
 - (D) 100 dollars
2. What percentage of the world's estimated 260 million home-based workers are women, according to WIEGO?
 - (A) 45%
 - (B) 57%
 - (C) 63%
 - (D) 70%
3. When was ILO Convention 177 adopted?
 - (A) June 20, 1990
 - (B) June 20, 1996
 - (C) July 4, 1996
 - (D) January 1, 2000
4. How many countries have ratified Convention 177?
 - (A) None from South Asia
 - (B) Over 50 worldwide
 - (C) Only 13 countries
 - (D) Every European country
5. According to ILO specialist Deepa Bharathi, why is home-based work in South Asia especially hard to regulate?
 - (A) Because workers refuse to join unions.
 - (B) Because it is often hidden in complex subcontracting chains.
 - (C) Because South Asian governments have banned such work.
 - (D) Because the ILO has no authority in the region.
6. What does the ILO say the focus must now be on, to help home-based workers?
 - (A) Stricter punishments for companies
 - (B) Visibility, fair pay, social protection, and a stronger collective voice
 - (C) Moving all workers into factories
 - (D) Banning all subcontracting

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive (legal milestone):** Convention 177 recognized for the first time in international law that home-based work is real work, worthy of the same dignity and rights as factory employment. The fact that activists managed to get it adopted against tough opposition is a major achievement that still inspires labor movements today.
- 2. Negative / critical (deep failure of implementation):** Three decades later, only 13 nations have signed it, and none from South Asia -- the very region with the largest number of home-based workers. Without ratification, the convention remains an empty promise, and women like Shehnaz Bano continue to be exploited in unsafe conditions for poverty wages.
- 3. Neutral / analytical (systemic barriers):** Home-based work is intentionally made invisible through complicated subcontracting chains that let brand-name companies avoid legal responsibility. Combined with ingrained gender bias that treats women's income as merely 'supplementary,' these structural factors create a wall that even good laws struggle to break through.
- 4. Forward-looking (what must change):** Getting more countries to ratify the convention and enforce it will require pressure from consumers, activists, and international organizations. Technology could help -- apps that map supply chains or digital payments that create financial records -- but the real shift will come when societies stop seeing home-based women workers as second-class laborers.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):
